women from that prison, she adds, and led to the "acceptance of flawed characters, especially women". Series creators are now freely exploring issues such as desire and sexuality, which were mostly taboo on family television.

Nandy calls OTT a "fabulously fertile time" for telling stories about women. Written and directed by women and labelled the desi *Sex & the City* by audiences, *Four More Shots Please!* (*FMSP!*) put a woman's desire front and centre. The show's success has led to Nandy being frequently asked to pitch a show in a similar lighter, urban chic landscape.

One undesirable fallout of women-centric scripts, however, is that most shows have become trapped in one genre—serious dramas. Conscious of that pitfall, Nandy has made the Cyndi Lauper classic 'Girls Just Wanna Have Fun' a mission statement of sorts at PNC. "*FMSP!* dives into the dark but does not sink in it," she says. "It's a show that is fun and can be watched over a night of binge drinking. It is not trying to teach you something or say the world around you sucks."

WOMEN ON TOP

The likes of Nandy are also finding themselves sharing ideas in a boardroom full of women. Content wings of at least four OTT platforms are spearheaded by women. If Pandey helms content at ZEE5, Tanya Bami heads the series slate for Netflix India, Aparna Purohit handles programming at Amazon Prime Video and Mrinalini Khanna is vice-president of originals at Lionsgate Play. Even their teams skew towards women. The female to male ratio in Bami's creative team, is 70:30. "We are big proponents of the female-fronted show and organically go seeking female-forward narratives," says Bami. According to her, 60 per cent of Netflix titles have women either leading the show or being central to the story.

With good reason, too. Women form a significant chunk of the OTT audience, but findings of ZEE5's internal data and

SLATED NEXT...

THE FAME GAME
Netflix

A Bollywood superstar (**Madhuri Dixit-Nene**) goes missing and out come many inconvenient secrets from her closet. Producer Karan Johar has called the show a "complex family drama" that captures the "complexities and hidden realities" of the reel world. The show releases on February 25.





FARAR, *Zee5*

Zindagi has become a bankable platform of the feminist cause with Pakistani shows *Churails* and *Qatil Haseenaon Ke Naam*. They are adding to the narrative with a "coming-of-age story of three imperfectly perfect women".

MAI, *Netflix*

Anushka Sharma's production company Clean Slate's new series centres on a 47-year-old wife and mother (**Sakshi Tanwar**) whose life turns upside down after she gets entangled in "a web of white-collar crime and dirty politics". Co-starring Seema Pahwa, Raima Sen and Wamiqa Gabbi.

